

Calendar

Wednesday, January 8

The Valley Players invites anyone for auditions for their upcoming production of "Honestly Now" by Jack Sharkey at 7:30 p.m. at the town hall. Four men and five women are needed. For more information call Terry Caron at 256-3635. Auditions continue Friday at the same time.

St. Mary's parish sponsors a series of six-hand euchres every Wednesday night this month starting at 7:30 p.m. Also Feb. 5 and 19. Games are played at St. Mary's school.

Thursday, January 9

A blood donor clinic will be held at Naimith Memorial Public School from 2-4:30 and 6-8 p.m.

Saturday, January 11

Big Brothers/Big Sisters of Lanark County fish for funds with the annual ice fishing derby on Clayton Lake. The derby runs from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. For more information, call Rod at 256-1541.



Sunday, January 12

Members and friends of the Central Lanark Pastoral Charge present the musical drama Joseph and the Amazing Technicolor Dreamcoat at the Almonte United Church at 3 p.m. Free will offering. All invited. For details, call Steve Cotnam at 256-2785.

ADAC Performing Arts holds a potluck for subscribers and friends at Ramsay Township hall at 12:30 p.m. There will be a traditional "Penny Reading" by Glen Lockwood and Reva Dolgoy.

Tuesday, January 14

The general meeting of the Almonte General Hospital Auxiliary starts at noon with a cafeteria lunch. The meeting begins at 12:30 in the hospital board room with speaker Ray Timmons, CEO. New volunteers are welcome.

The Taoist Tia Chi Society of Ottawa begins a 10-week course tonight from 8-9 p.m. at Carleton Place High School. Experience a sense of relaxation and added balance in this ancient Chinese Healing Art, suitable for all ages and levels of ability. Call 257-4269 for information.

Wednesday, January 15

Lanark Woodworking Club meets at Charlie Heslop's, east side of 12th Line, Ramsay, between Old Almonte and Hamilton Sideroad, starting at 7 p.m. Bring idea or project to display. For information, call 257-7942 or 257-7188.

Thursday, January 16

The Mississippi Valley Field Naturalists host a 7:30 p.m. talk at the Mill of Kintail by Brian Naylor on the seven-year program monitoring the red-shouldered hawks and goshawks in Lanark County. No need to be an MVFN member to attend. For details, call 257-8206 or 257-2164.

Note: Take Young People Seriously (TYPS) Almonte needs adult and youth volunteers for the Vent Youth Centre. If you have a few hours a month to spare, call 256-2295.

Note: Parents and tots can drop in to the Reformed Presbyterian Church hall Tuesday and Thursday mornings from 9:30 to 11:30 a.m. For details, call Glenna Watts at 256-6816.

Note: Once again the Canadian Cancer Society needs your help to recruit caring, community minded volunteers throughout Lanark County. People with approximately five hours a month are needed to fill a variety of volunteer positions. Some are short term, and some long term. Positions include treasurers, fundraising volunteers, patient services chairs, special events helpers, office volunteers, health promotion volunteers and in some areas, drivers. If you are looking to make a difference in the fight against cancer, please call 1-800-367-2913 for more information.

Town's Lions Club celebrates 50 years of helping others

By Gena Gibson and Lois Tuffin
Gazette staff

Bob France thinks there will always be need for service groups such as the Lions Club.

"With the people that belong to it and the interest in it and the things to be done, it doesn't surprise me that it's been quite successful," France, 84, said of the club's 50 years in Almonte. "It will continue on into the future."

"I think there's a good need for it."

France was one of the charter members of the club when it began back in June of 1947. He is the only surviving member of the 35 men who started the Lions tradition in town.

"I enjoyed every minute of it," said France, who retired from the club about 10 years ago. "There was always something — the service club is well-named."

He remembered that the Ottawa West Lions Club helped start the Almonte version, joining in a celebration beside the town hall in June.

"All the townspeople gathered and had a great day," he said.

Stewart Lee, 76, joined the club while he was in his early 30's. His father had been a charter member, and he says he joined for the fellowship and to serve the community.

"My father resigned and I went in," he remembered. Although he helped with the Easter Seals campaign for many years, he still thinks he could have done more.

"It was tough when I was really busy (running his family's hardware store) to find the time to do things," he admitted. "I feel now I didn't do enough."

Through the years, the Lions Club has supported



Lions (from left) Rick Sulpher, Carl Sadler, Jack Virgin and Reg Gamble posed with the late Mertie McDonald and Fairview Manor worker Sheila Lefebvre in June of 1994. The Lions contributed money to the purchase of a new van.

many local and national projects. From 1947 to 1993, the club raised more than \$1 million for the construction of the new hospital and its chronic care wing, Fairview Manor and the library.

Club members also helped build the town's first skating rink in the 1940's and donated more than \$100,000 toward the community centre. Other projects have included the R. Tait McKenzie scholarships and two vans for Fairview Manor residents.

"The projects over the years have always kept changing as people evolve," Lee explained. "When they die out you try and find something else that will be more of a money maker for the community."

"Right now we're doing very well with bingos in Carleton Place."

Herb Pragnell, the club president in 1966, said the Lions started out as a businessmen's club because the town didn't have

one.

Pragnell, John Cameron and Gerry Wheatley were the first "commuters" to join, Pragnell said. Soon after, one-quarter of the membership was people who worked in Ottawa.

Pragnell started the R. Tait McKenzie scholarships as the club's project to celebrate Canada's centennial in 1967. It rewards the male and female graduating students at Almonte and District High School who best reflect the ideals of Dr. Robert Tait McKenzie, a pioneer in rehabilitation.

Times changing

Pragnell said the club's focus has changed in recent years. It allowed women to join as full members a few years ago, with the first woman inducted June 21, 1994.

The club now recruits fewer members because people tend to donate their time to one cause, such as hockey.

"In the past, people came

to us with large projects," Pragnell said. "Now they start a group and ask us for a donation."

Lee suggested the club needs an influx of new members.

"You need younger people to help man some of these projects," he said, adding younger men dominated the membership list when he joined.

Since its inception, the Lions Club has always had 30-50 members. They pay a \$35 initiation fee and then \$55 in fees every year, which gives members two magazines from Lions International.

"You get a feeling that you're serving and you get the comradeship of working with others," Pragnell said. "The big advantage is you can tackle projects you couldn't do alone."

France agreed.

"There's always a need for these things to help other people if you just look around," he said. "If I can help somebody, I'm more than happy to do it."

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